

source software to help you get there. You'll find nearly all of them in ArtistX, which you can boot into using this month's DVD.

## Before It All Begins

You can't just inflict your camera-toting self on the world and hope to create the next big thing in film-making. Apart from a sense of reality, you need a plan. Convenient though it might be, great movies don't just *happen*—they start with scripts, storyboards and characters. For that, you need Celtx.

Celtx (you'll find it on our July CD) calls itself a "media pre-production" tool for prospective movie makers. It lets you take your movie from a fleeting idea to a well-planned project. It lets you outline your story, create a screenplay and storyboard for your movie and add characters' profiles. If you're a more serious film-maker, you can use Celtx to set

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tion. The next step would be to start building your screenplay, and then the storyboard. While you're writing your screenplay, Celtx makes things easier for you by letting you add annotations and notes, and by giving you an autocomplete menu when you start typing character names.

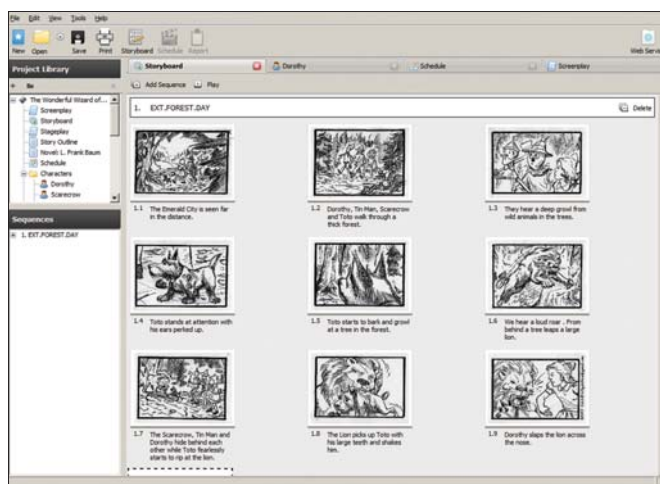
Once you've made a plan, you just need to execute it.

## Aside: The Lazy (?) Way

If you don't want to shoot your own footage—whether it's laziness or a lack of equipment—there are sources on the Internet where you can get yourself a whole cornucopia of raw footage, just waiting to be edited and mixed into a new film. One such site is MOD Films ([www.modfilms.com](http://www.modfilms.com)), where you can get your hands on over nine hours of raw footage, loads of concept art and more. They've even made their own re-mixable movie, called *Sanctuary*, which you can modify to your own tastes. But we digress...

## Capture And Cut Up

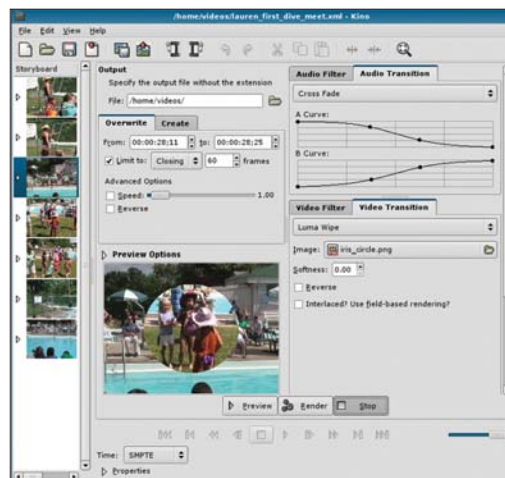
If your camera uses a proprietary driver to connect to your PC, chances are you have no choice but to use its own bundled software to dump video to your drive (Sony camcorders are quite notorious in this respect). You could use VirtualDub—a greatly undermined tool—to import



If you're serious about making your movie, you should start with Celtx

filming schedules, manage actors, wardrobe and props.

Celtx starts new projects with a screenplay and a storyboard, and you can right-click in the left pane to add items like a story outline to descriptions of special effects you intend to employ. A logical way to start would be to add a story outline before anything else. Next, add your characters: give them family backgrounds, eccentricities, even a physical descrip-



Kino is the need of the hour to turn lots of raw footage into a decent movie

## Off-track

**Y**ou don't really need to go out and shoot real people and real things to make a movie—if you've got a webcam or a respectable PC and lots of determination, you can create your own stop-motion or 3D movie, à la *Elephants Dream*, which is easily the most famous open source movie in recent times. What you need:

### Blender

Its interface takes getting used to, and creating a good 3D model takes plenty of skill—not to mention animating it—but Blender lets you create some really amazing animations. Setting up animations for human and animal models is made easy with its Skeleton Creation Mode and walk cycles, and you can use Python to write more complex animation scripts.

### Stopmotion

The good thing about stop-motion animation is that you only need a webcam at home to do it, but that good is quickly offset by the amount of work that'll go into your actually creating a stop-motion feature.

Stopmotion is a simple tool. There's not much technology can do when your biggest effort involves moving the arms and legs of a doll while ensuring that your set or camera doesn't change position by even an inch. But it does offer you a few helpful features like Onion Skinning, which lets you overlay previous shots over your current camera view, so you can create a tighter, more fluid-looking animation.